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Ticket to Ride?

A Greek Ostrakon from the Roman Fort at Arad Reconsidered*

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ABSTRACT: This article presents a re-edition of a Greek ostrakon from excavations at Tel Arad (ancient Arad) and advances a new interpretation of the text, which has been little noted since its first publication, in relation to the provision of mounts at the site's Roman fort. Specifically, though firm conclusions remain elusive, the document may have been a signed order granting a travelling party a change of mounts at the outpost at Arad.

THE campaigns at Tel Arad (ancient Arad), conducted under the auspices of the Israel Museum, the Department of Antiquities and Museums, Israel Exploration Society and National Parks Authority, yielded two ostraca with texts in Greek, alongside a larger number in Hebrew and Aramaic.¹ The purpose of this note is to propose a new reading and interpretation of the more substantial of the Greek texts. This ostrakon was given only an incomplete transcription by its first editor, who regarded it as 'too incomplete to understand', but it may shed light on the otherwise poorly attested Roman phase of the site. The sherd was found in stratum III of the citadel, a context corresponding to the 'Roman citadel' of the first century CE.² This fortress is believed to have stood along the southern *limes* of the Roman province before the annexation of the kingdom of Nabataea, after which it fell into disuse until the early Islamic period (Aharoni and Amiran 1964: 144; Aharoni 1993: 85). Alongside it there was a town, which was still inhabited in the time of Eusebius.³

* I thank two anonymous readers of *IEJ* for helpful criticisms on the edition and the IAA for permission to reproduce the photograph shown in fig. 1.

1 First published by B. Lipshitz in Aharoni 1981: 177, nos. 1–2. Only the first text (no. 1 of Lipshitz) will be treated here; the second is a small fragment preserving only a few letters. Both texts are addenda to the survey of Cotton, Cockle and Millar 1995. Abbreviations for epigraphical publications here follow *SEG*; for papyrological publications, see the checklist at <http://papyri.info/docs/checklist>.

2 Aharoni 1981: 8–9 with Herzog *et al.* 1984: 30. The dating to the first century BCE given in Aharoni 1993: 85 is presumably a typographical error.

3 Eusebius, *Onomasticon* 14.1–3 (similarly Procopius of Gaza, *On Judges* 1:16, PG 87.1:1045). For historical references to the site see, further, Tsafir, Di Segni and Green 1994: 66.

The substrate and its dimensions were not described by the first editor. From the published photograph the sherd appears to belong to the body of a storage vessel, light grey in colour, written in black ink with a thick pen parallel to the wheel marks on the convex side. This photograph (fig. 1) shows that the six-line text is in fact complete, despite some fading, and also allows a complete Greek word to be read in the second line, which may provide a clue to the rest: κτήνη ‘animals’, which in the period to which the text belongs can denote more specifically ‘beasts of burden’, including ‘horses’.⁴ The numeral ‘four’, specifying the quantity of animals, can then be read in the following line (τέσσερα), and a slight modification of the reading of the first editor in the opening line, [E]ΠΑΛΛΑΙ to ἐπ’ ἀλλαγ() for ἀλλαγ(ῃ) or ἀλλαγ(ῆς)—for which see further the commentary below—may situate the text more precisely in the ‘changing’ of a specific number of horses at a post-station, although another sense of ἀλλαγὴ as ‘barter’ cannot be entirely excluded.

In fact, the fortress commanded a site near the junction of two roads, one running east–west between Gaza, Beersheba and the shores of the Dead Sea, and another north–south between Jerusalem, Hebron and Mampsis (Aharoni and Amiran 1964: 132 with the map in fig. 1). The end of the text consists of a personal name possibly followed by a patronym, the interpretation of which remains uncertain, and the statement ‘I have signed’ (σῆσθ— for σεσημείωμαι), indicating this man as the issuer and authenticator of the note, which may have functioned as a sort of pass redeemable for fresh horses. The ostrakon presumably lay discarded at the site and may have been written elsewhere and carried there, suggesting that Arad itself was the location of the ‘changing’, after which the sherd, having served its purpose, was jettisoned.

Lack of further contextual details, such as archaeological evidence for stables or livestock pens at the site or relevant historical testimony, prevents a determination as to whether this changing, if accepted, belonged to a formal *cursus publicus* or a special mission. In later references to organized post-stations, the same term ἀλλαγὴ appears as used here (see commentary below). On the basis of Aramaic ostraca from the site’s Persian period, a way-station and supply centre for cavalry has been located there (Aharoni 1993: 84), but continuity in

4 Arndt and Danker 2000: 572 s.v.; see in particular Luke 10:34 and Acts 23:24: in the former κτήνος, which could be a horse, donkey, or mule, is ridden by a traveller (ὁδεύων) on the Jerusalem–Jericho road; in the latter, horses are strongly implied if not explicitly specified for κτήνη, as the context is the dispatch of Paul to the Roman governor at Caesarea Maritima, escorted by soldiers and cavalrymen (ἵππεῖς) along the coastal road, a journey for the last leg of which Paul is in fact accompanied solely by the ἵππεῖς (23:32–33). In other contexts, the term could describe livestock more generally.

the Hellenistic and Roman periods cannot be taken for granted. In any case, the availability of extra horses at a Roman fort would not be surprising.

The workings of roadside Roman forts are best documented in Egypt's Eastern Desert, from papyrological and epigraphic data and from archaeological remains of the structures themselves in the first through third centuries CE. The forts served primarily to control traffic along the roads, as well as to ensure the availability of water and other supplies to travellers, amid dry conditions comparable to those in the vicinity of Arad.⁵ Garrisons of ten to fifteen soldiers, along with mounted cavalry for postal dispatches, were the norm. For the purpose of provisioning and the sustenance of staff stationed there, bread ovens and livestock pens were also a feature (Reddé 2018), though zooarchaeological evidence suggests that the rather low real consumption of meat on the spot derived primarily from pork as a cured import and only occasionally the product of local husbandry, followed by sheep and goats slaughtered locally (Leguilloux 2018). Cattle, which might otherwise be an obvious referent for the 'animals' (κτῆνη) in the present text, are conspicuously absent from the comparable documentation in Egypt.

For convenience, a re-edition, translation and commentary on the Arad text, based on the published photograph, are presented here. In the absence of autopsy, it should be taken with due caution.

EDITION

O.Arad I (fig. 1)

Ticket for fresh mounts (?)

First century CE

Editio princeps B. Lipshitz

apud Aharoni 1981: 177, no. 1

Dimensions not recorded

- | | |
|---------|---------------------------|
| 1 | ἐπ' ἀλλαγ() |
| 2 | κτῆνη |
| 3 | τέσσερα [.] . . |
| 4 | κουστε . |
| 5 | αν . . // |
| 6 (m2?) | <i>vac.</i> σεσ(ημείωμαι) |

Apparatus

- | | |
|---|---------------------------|
| 1 | ἀλλαγ/ ostr. 6 σεσ– ostr. |
|---|---------------------------|

5 See the reports collected in Brun *et al.* 2018, especially the contributions of Brun 2018; Van der Veen *et al.* 2018; Reddé 2018; and Leguilloux 2018.

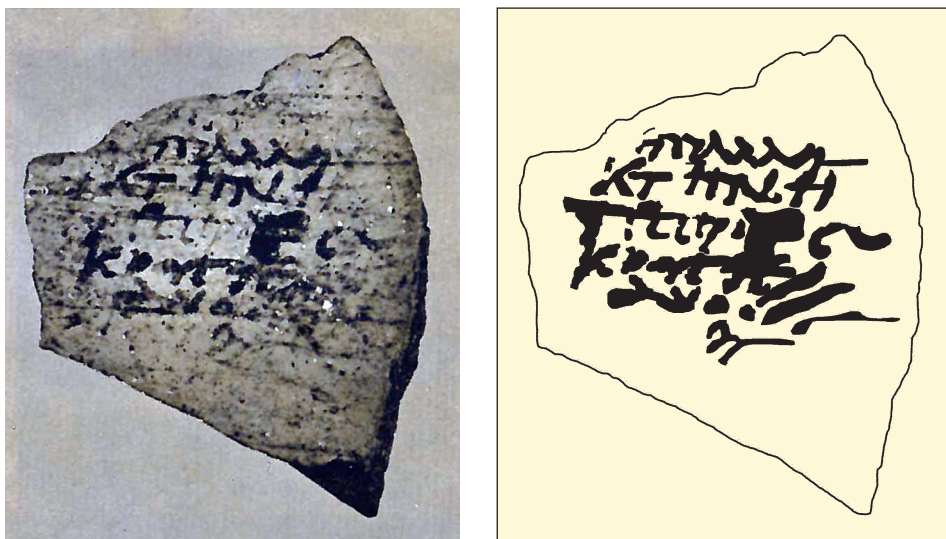


Fig. 1. *O. Arad 1*: a) photograph (after Aharoni 1981: 177; reprinted by permission of the Israel Antiquities Authority, which holds the copyright); b) line-drawing (by the author)

Translation

For exchange: four mounts (?). I [N or NN] have signed.

COMMENTARY

Line 1. — ἐπ' ἀλλαγ(): probably to be expanded ἐπ' ἀλλαγ(ῆ) or ἐπ' ἀλλαγ(ῆς); [ἐ]π' ἀλλαι *editio princeps*. The sense for ἀλλαγῆ of 'exchange' or 'changing' of horses for fresh mounts, and by metonymy a post or station on a road, is not securely attested alongside σταθμός until later, Byzantine texts (*P.Oxy.* XVI 1862.45 with commentary; *Stud.Pal.* VIII 807, 952; LSJ s.v. III), but can be recognized in the region in the place-name ἡ Ἀλλαγῆ 'The Post-Station', a stop on the itinerary set out in the fourth-century archive of Theophanes (e.g., *P.Ryl.* IV 627.242–243), on the coastal road between Antipatris and Caesarea Maritima. On the organization of the *cursus publicus* (δημόσιος δρόμος) and *mutationes* (σταθμοί), see Procopius, *Secret History* 30.3–7; *RE* IV 1848. Five horses are fixed as the maximum number available in any single change, without special written permission, in a constitution of 378 (*Codex Theodosianus* 8.5.35 with *RE* XIV.1 1242 s.v. *mansio*).

At this earlier date, the basic meaning 'change' (Arndt and Danker 2000: 45 s.v. ἀλλαγῆ), which was for example applied to 'shifts' or changes of personnel at military lookout points in a second-century military roster on an ostrakon (*SB XX* 14180.43), in conjunction with a reference to κτήνη and the context of a Roman

fort, may have sufficed to make the point clear, but the interpretation cannot be considered certain. In the absence of any mention of money, the common technical sense of ἐπ' ἀλλαγῆς to denote a currency-exchange fee is not probable here. The ἀλλαγή might denote more generally 'exchange' or 'barter' of goods, in which case the ostrakon would have to do with the acquisition rather than the requisition of mounts, but one might expect such essential provisions to have been supplied to the station by military authorities as a more reliable source, not left up to local initiative. As noted in the introduction, acquisition of cattle in this case is unlikely due to the desert setting.

Line 2. — κτήνη: ἐτηνη or στηνη *editio princeps*.

Line 3. — τέσσαρα [.]: πετρου . *editio princeps*; the variant spelling τέσσαρα is not excluded. The cancelled letter was perhaps ε, which the α has partially overwritten. The writer may have begun τέσσερες.

Lines 3–5. — . . . κουστε . αν . . . : . . . κουγ . εανος (?) *editio princeps*. A personal name for the signatory (see line 6 below) is expected, perhaps Ἀῦκουσταιανός, a variant spelling for the Αὐγουστιανός (Latin Augustianus) that is well represented in Greek in the Roman period, including the name of a citizen of Syrian Antioch attested at Thyateira (*TAM* V.2.1016 with *RE* XVIII.4 s.v. Paris [5]), but while the intervocalic interchange of /g/ and /k/ is attested in common nouns (Gignac 1976: 79–80) it is not yet paralleled in proper names at this date (in the Islamic period cf. Ἀκουστίνο(υ) for Αὐγουστίνου in *P.Lond.* IV 1610.56). It is also possible that the text should be divided into two names (the signer's name in the nominative followed by a patronym), though this division yields nothing very satisfactory: perhaps Αὔκουζ Τελάνθουζ with the last two letters compressed (for Αὔκτοζ, Latin Auctus), with *Συκοῦζ (cf. Συκᾶς, *LGPN* IIIA s.v.) a more remote possibility for the first name, or *Εὔκοῦζ as hypocoristic of the Εὔκουρος on record in Roman Arabia (*SEG* VII 1203).

Line 5. — //. The diagonal filler strokes were omitted in the *editio princeps*. They perhaps serve to prevent tampering.

Line 6. — σῃς(ημείωμα). This line was omitted in the *editio princeps*. The verb, variously abbreviated, is ubiquitous in documents to denote signatures; for the present form, in which the bow of the second sigma is simply extended to the right to mark the abbreviation, cf., e.g., *O.Bru.* 2.7 (Thebes, 67 CE); *O.Stras.* I 78.5 (Thebes, 55 CE). Probably the text was drawn up by a professional scribe, possibly in bulk, then authorized by the signatory in his own hand.

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